

Paper 4: Post-Fascism

The conclusion of C.G Tamas' piece on "Post-Fascism" is highly reminiscent of the critiques of the legal scholar, Linda Bosniak, in her contribution to Juan F. Perea's book "Immigrants Out!: The New Nativism and the Anti-Immigrant Impulse of the United States". Titled " 'Nativism' the Concept: Some Reflections" (1997), Bosniak characterizes what she takes to be her version of Tamas' post-fascist state. Similar to Tamas, Bosniak emphasizes how post-National Socialist fascism paints a picture that is simultaneously more benign yet infinitely more unsolvable in ways than its 20th century predecessor. The reason being, and both authors would agree on this, is the contradiction-filled abstraction of citizenship, a problem which has existed since the Enlightenment, went unsolved in the post-war era, and remains persistent to this day. The banality of this evil is presented masterfully by Tamas. "The scission of citizenship and sub-political humanity is now complete... Post-fascism does not need to put non-citizens into freight trains to take them into death; instead, it need only prevent the new non-citizens from boarding any trains that might take them into the happy world of overflowing rubbish bins that could feed them" (pg. 25)

In essence, the distinction between liberal capitalist democracy and fascism can be simplified to a matter of presentation. According to thinkers like Bataille and Schmitt, sovereign power is defined by the exception and is heterogenous as a result, determined on a case by case basis. For the sake of economic efficiency, capitalist democracy insisted that "civic and human

community” were one in the same. The followers of cosmopolitanism pushed this idea and left the glaring problems of this logic to the periphery, to the colonies (referring back to last week’s discussion) where violence and inequality were clear as day. When the boomerang came home, fascism became the attempt to end this pantomime, to reveal the sovereign in all his awesome, totalizing power as the arbitrary judge in who does and does not belong in the civic community. In Tamas’ words, “Cutting the civic and human community in two: this is fascism.” (pg. 16).

Most importantly, the defeat of Nazi Germany did not extinguish these axioms. According to Bosniak, the sovereignty principle affirms the priority of particular people, that being, the citizens of that country, over any universalizing claims to humanity. Liberals can pull every answer they have from their bag, one like America is “a nation of immigrants” yet fail to acknowledge that such an answer presumes an American openness to migrants must serve American material interests. Immigrants are free to pursue the American dream because they are useful to America. In response to nativist accusations that immigrants are a drain on the economy, are we left to rely on the continuous favorability of this cost argument less the results of a shrinking economic pie force us to concede that although the argument is usually wrong on the facts, there is nothing intrinsically xenophobic about the worry over jobs, overpopulation, and the austerity of the public purse. To Bosniak, this is the Left’s greatest vulnerability. She *writes* that nationalist particularism marks the permissible end of the legitimacy spectrum and that the assumed preference of citizens over foreigners lies at the genesis of contemporary political thought, a truth that fascism is not interested in hiding.

What, then, remains to be done? Post-fascism doesn’t need the stormtroopers or the prison camps to sustain itself, but a steady flow of the aforementioned nativist, anti-immigrant sentiments. According to Tamas, there is no future in combatting this by focusing on ethnicity,

the kinds of identity politics which liberals are so fond of. These are what Tamas calls “multiculturalist responses” that are “desperate avowals of impotence” (pg. 30). Per Bosniak’s argument, even if “America First” was completely devoid of its racist and xenophobic undertones, it could still exist in a way that presents a rational argument for the Right. The reality now is that these far-right, post-fascist groups are becoming bolder in their rhetoric of racialized supremacy and hatred because attempts to reconcile the Normative State, i.e., the centers of global capital and the Prerogative State, that concerning the nation state have all been futile. Instead, we must focus on one, and Tamas is of the opinion that the true target lies in the Normative State. Socialism, in his mind, is how we surmount the Normative State which currently only serves the few. To this, I pose the momentous question to the class, are we convinced by his argument?